A WOMAN GODHEAD AS AN ELEMENTAL FORCE—like a storm or the earth itself. In terms of psychological geography, Bengal is still fertile soil for this ancient archetype. And you can well imagine her as a piece of Kalighat *patua* art painted on a sari: an incarnation of totemic feminine power stomping on male divinities, as a series of larger-than-life rivals, beginning from Jyoti Basu, have found. So when even the BJP ruefully likened Mamata Banerjee to "Goddess Durga", it went beyond a casual association. It spoke to some quintessence of Didi's persona: earthy, truculent, always coming at you with such gale-force as to seem supernal. Of course, like the earth, Mamata has her seasons. Throughout her 40 years in politics, she has changed her deportment at will. From being Rajiv Gandhi's 'younger sister' to being Arvind Kejriwal's 'elder sister'. Or, to give the longform version, from being a Chhatra Parishad stormtrooper in the Indira era, then a renegade who formed a new party but never lost her defining animus with the Left, then a minister in the Vajpayee cabinet who always had to have her way (and her railway line), back to forming an off-and-on sorority with Sonia Gandhi, cultivating an outspoken and mutual vendetta politics against the Narendra Modi-led BJP, but not without occasional off-the-record goss on tacit distress bargaining.

In short, Mamata has supped at every table. Each forkful has fortified her castle. To her credit, at every turn of the tortuous path, she manages to appear as the genuine article, answering the need of the hour, like magma erupting to restore geological order. Power effected no change on her essential trait: the feistiest of politicians, the sheer physicality of her presence evokes a near-oneness with an angry Bengal. Her words often help make that metaphorical leap: "The CPI(M) has beaten me a lot. Several parts of my body, from head to toe are broken. Yet they couldn't stop me," she has said. Of late, she tosses a dare to the BJP: "If that beating couldn't stop me, do you think you can?" This street-fighter swag is what the CM of 12 years and five-time parliamentarian draws on for her supreme demotic loyalty, even corruption charges against the TMC not quite sullying her image as the didi who still lives a simple life in the tiled-roof house next door, wearing ordinary slippers and white saris. ■

–Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

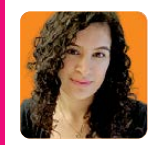
↘ FITNESS FIRST
Mamata sweats it out regularly, fixing a daily target and ensuring that she walks as many steps

↘ HER OWN DRAPE
The length of her sari is longer than what is commonly used in Bengal—a full seven yards, instead of the regular 6.2 yards

↘ FUN MUNCH
Her favourite evening snack is muri-alur chop—puffed rice eaten with deep-fried and spiced mashed potatoes

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